



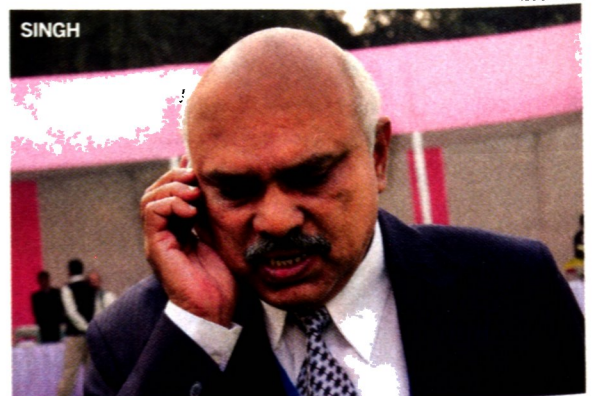
WELL GROOMED

A DAY AFTER Valentine's Day, 80 tribal Muslim and Hindu couples from across West Bengal were wedded at a simple ceremony in Bahirkhand village, 60 km from Kolkata. The day-long marriage ceremony was organised by an NGO. The ceremony was an indicator that religion can unite more than just couples.

PATNA | Call Weight

For a bureaucrat in Bihar, the sky is the limit for receiving calls. For the past week, Chief Secretary R.J.M. Pillai's cellphone has been ringing over 200 times a day. That's not all. HRD Secretary Anjani Kumar Singh's phone has outdone Pillai's by far. These are not pesky promotion calls. The babus in Bihar have to take the calls after Chief Minister Nitish Kumar made numbers of some officials public last week to let the common man have access to the higher echelons in the state Government. Some call Pillai at 4 a.m. just to see if he answers. Although the babus are reticent to express their unhappiness on record, their sympathisers say that Nitish should make numbers of all bureaucrats public instead of announcing a select few. Better still, as some say, the chief minister should start taking these calls personally to have a first-hand access to the pulse of the people.

by Amitabh Srivastava



TWO TOP OFFICERS HAVE HAD TO TAKE CALLS EVEN AT 4 A.M. AFTER NITISH PUBLICISED THEIR NUMBERS